The 2026 Memory Price Surge and the AI Bubble

Summary Report

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1. Project objectives

Show with data **why RAM and SSD prices surged in 2025–26, who pays, who profits, and whether the AI spending behind it is a bubble**. Delivered as a 6-minute video built on eleven animated charts.

2. Novel contributions

- **Three compiled datasets:** DDR4 chip contract prices (monthly, 2022–2026), Big Tech capex (quarterly, 2022–2025, from SEC filings) and SK hynix profit (quarterly, 4Q22–2Q26).
- **The full cycle in one chart:** the chip price fell 62% to $1.30, then rose 20× to $26, with three dated events marked (Figure 1).
- **Spending vs price on one timeline:** capex rose 3.7× from 2024; prices followed from mid-2025 (Figure 2).
- **Both sides:** PC prices +17% for consumers; SK hynix went from a 3.4tn-won loss to a 60.5tn-won profit.
- **A balanced bubble verdict:** write-downs and a slowdown, not a crash, with three scenarios for memory prices.

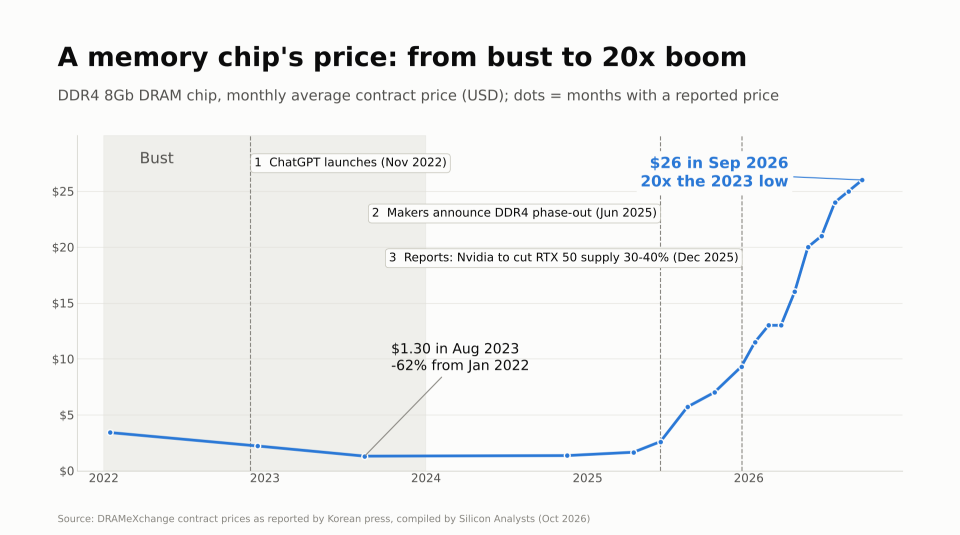


Figure 1: DDR4 8Gb contract price, Jan 2022 to Sep 2026, with three dated events.

3. Technical challenges

- **Paywalled data:** we rebuilt the price series from monthly press reports and checked each value against its source.
- **Irregular sampling:** only 18 months have a price, so we plot dots on a true date axis to keep the gaps visible.
- **Mismatched sources:** capex datasets with different scopes stay in separate charts, with estimates marked.
- **A confounder:** DDR4 is being phased out, which inflates its rise; we flag this and cross-check with DDR5 prices.
- **Honest animation:** fixed scales and zero baselines in every clip, in one colourblind-safe palette.

4. Conclusion

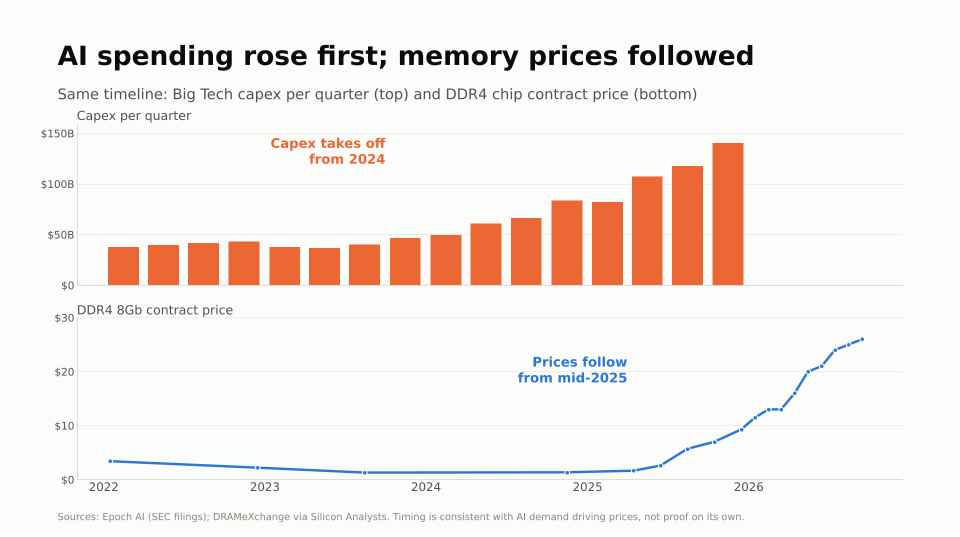


Figure 2: Big Tech capex per quarter (top) and DDR4 contract price (bottom).

The memory price surge is a side effect of the AI build-out: spending rose first, makers shifted capacity to AI, and prices followed. The squeeze reached consumers, including a reported 30–40% cut in Nvidia RTX 50 supply. AI demand is real, but the build-out may run ahead of revenue. If spending slows, cyclical memory prices could fall as fast as they rose. Figure 2 shows the timing fits, though timing alone does not prove cause.

5. Contributions by each student

Student	Matric ID	Contribution
Ayush Bhatt	G2610412E	Initial idea, initial draft, finding the datasets.
Bu Dinglin	_____	*[To be completed: e.g. narration and recording, video editing, script review, fact-checking.]*

Sources: Silicon Analysts / DRAMeXchange; Epoch AI (SEC filings); SK hynix results releases; TrendForce; Gartner; Counterpoint Research; UBS via 24/7 Wall St.; Morgan Stanley via Benzinga; IoT Analytics. Full references in the report.